

ESSENTIAL

F-1 Student Visa Master Guide

The complete walkthrough - SEVIS, the I-20, the DSO's role, and FAQs

VERIFY BEFORE YOU APPLY

Fees, forms, and processing times change without notice. This guide reflects publicly documented procedures as commonly published; treat every dollar figure, form number, and timeline here as a starting point, and confirm the current version on the official government site before you submit anything or pay any fee.

What the F-1 visa is - and the role of SEVIS

The F-1 visa lets you study full-time at a Student and Exchange Visitor Program (SEVP)-approved school in the US. Your entire application is anchored to your SEVIS record: your school's Designated School Official (DSO) creates it and issues your Form I-20 once you're admitted and have shown evidence of funding, and that same SEVIS ID follows you through the SEVIS fee payment, the DS-160, your visa interview, and your status once you're studying in the US.

The process end to end

Step	What happens
1. Get admitted and receive your I-20	Your school's DSO issues this once you've shown evidence of funding matching the school's stated cost figure.
2. Pay the SEVIS I-901 fee	A separate fee from the visa application fee, tied to your SEVIS ID - pay before booking your interview.
3. Complete the DS-160 and pay the visa fee (MRV fee)	The standard nonimmigrant visa application form and fee.
4. Book and attend your interview	At the US embassy/consulate with jurisdiction over your location - an in-person interview is standard for this visa category.
5. Decision	Generally given the same day, though administrative processing can add delay in specific cases.
6. Travel within the timing rules	Visa issuance no more than 120 days before your I-20 start date; entry to the US no more than 30 days before it.

Your school's DSO

The Designated School Official manages your SEVIS record from admission through graduation, and is your point of contact for anything that affects your status - including requesting a deferred program start date on your I-20 if your visa is delayed or refused close to your original term start, which keeps your SEVIS record active rather than requiring a completely fresh application.

Frequently asked questions

Can I work on an F-1 visa?

Limited on-campus work is generally permitted. Off-campus training - Curricular Practical Training (CPT) during your studies, or Optional Practical Training (OPT) after completing your program - is separately authorised through your DSO and USCIS, and isn't something your visa itself grants automatically.

What if I'm bringing my spouse or children?

They apply separately for F-2 dependent visas, tied to your SEVIS record - and your school's stated cost figure on the I-20 generally needs to reflect additional funds to support them, not just you. See the Financial Requirements Overview.

What if I'm refused?

See the Refusal Decision Guide (Premium tier) for what actually helps, given there's no formal appeal against a 214(b) refusal.